tracks and rocky areas behind Vasant Vihar. My brother and his friends, who were all senior to me in school, used to tease me mercilessly about my having a crush on Shaila. True or not, Shaila did send me a nice crystal piece as a present when I got married, which we have even now, forty years later. Raju and I remained friends even after we moved to SO Flats in 1972, often having sleepovers, and even after I moved out of Delhi. We are in contact even now, thanks mainly to WhatsApp.

During this period, my father was posted at the Air Force Station, Race Course Road. He enrolled us for riding classes in the school run by 61 Cavalry on Safdarjung Road. The 61 Cavalry Riding School has moved out since then to Brar Square in Delhi Cantonment, but the civil riding school is still there. My father would drop us off for our riding class and then hop across to the Air Force Station to play golf and look into golfing matters since he was also the Golf Secretary. After our class, we used to cut across to the golf course through a shortcut, and we would all come back together. We used to go about thrice a week and became proficient riders, even doing some of the smaller jumps. I also had my first fall then; I must have been in the 7th Standard. That day, my mother had come to drop/pick us up and was watching us ride. She says all was well; she just turned around for a moment and when she looked back, I was on the ground. Even I cannot recollect what happened, though I remember the corral and the spot at which I fell even now. The *ustaad* (instructor) made me get back on the horse despite my mother's most vehement protests, explaining to her that it was the only way to get rid of the fear of falling as well as to show the horse who was the 'master'. I had sprained my left wrist rather badly, had to wear a sling and was a mini-hero in class for a few days. The horses were not all of an even temperament. We used to carry

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